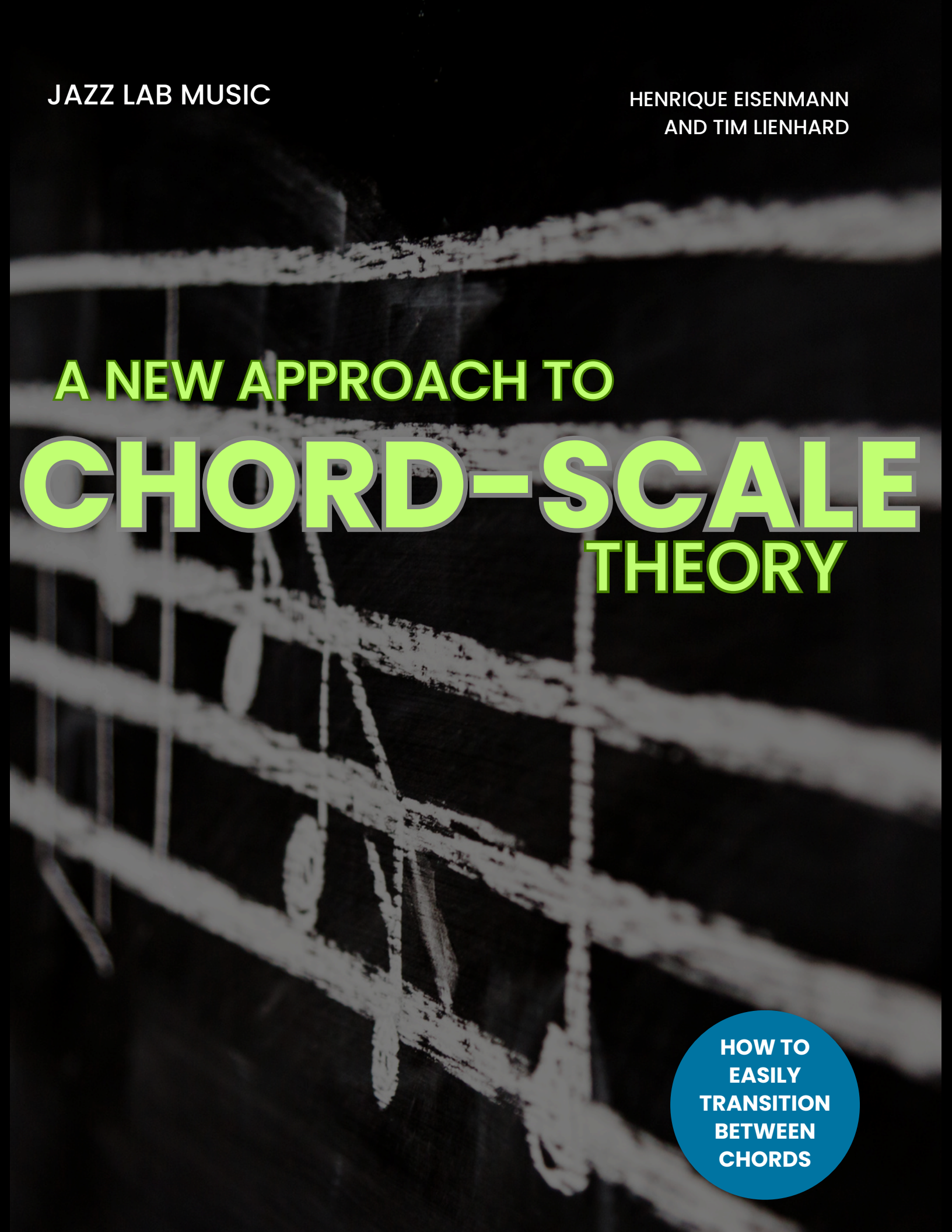
JAZZ LAB MUSIC

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A NEW APPROACH TO CHORD-SCALE THEORY



HOW TO EASILY TRANSITION BETWEEN CHORDS

This e-book is written by a human, not AI.

Please forgive the typos and grammar mistakes.

Chord-Scale Theory



One of the most common topics within Jazz pedagogy is chord-scale theory - the study of which scales should be played over each different type of chords. For example, we often learn to use the Lydian mode over a major chord, or the Dorian mode over a minor scale, different options for dominant chords (Mixolydian, or Altered, or octatonic, etc). This knowledge is important, since we must address the changes (chords) correctly when improvising melodies, just like having the correct alphabet for each type of chord. Modern jazz generally features complex harmonies, making it very hard to play intuitively by ear, so knowing the scales and the different options for each type of chord is extremely important.

However, chord-scale theory can very often become a hindrance, as it forces a vertical thinking (thinking about each individual chord) as opposed to a horizontal thinking (melodies flowing seamlessly threading between chords). The excess of a chord-scale approach can lead to a "boxed" improvisation, overly compartmentalized, in which there's no sense of naturalness in the melody. All notes used may be correct, but the improvisation doesn't sound organic and fluent. It requires a mental re-booth every time you move to a new chord.

Because of these issues, we would like to propose a new way to think about chord scale theory - one that prioritizes fluency, motivic development and lyricism.

Traditional Chord-Scale Theory

Here's a textbook example of traditional chord-scale theory:

Major Chords: use Major scale (Ionian mode) or Lydian mode.

Minor Chords: use the Dorian mode or the Natural minor scale (Aeolian mode)

Diminished Chords: use the diminished scale (whole-half).

Half-diminished Chords: use the Locrian #2

Dominant Chords: here you have endless options, depending on what tensions are highlighted by the harmony: use Mixolydian for chords with 9, 13 or sus; use Altered scale for chords with b9, #9, #11, b13; use the octatonic (half-whole diminished) for chords with b9, #11, 13.

Augmented chords with maj7: use the Ionian #5 or the Lydian #5 scales.

Sus chords with b9: use a Spanish Phrygian, or a Mixolydian b9.

As you can see, this can get quite complicated...

Experienced improvisers internalize all these options; But when you are learning to improvise it can become extremely hard to process so much information, and as a result your solos may sound truncated, disconnected, boxed, or overly "theoretical".

HERE'S OUR SOLUTION

Focusing on the differences

We will still use chord-scale theory, but now we will re-write all the scales starting from the same pitch (it can be the tonic, or any other note).

This will allow us to focus more on the changes and differences between scales, instead of seeing them as independent entities.

Let's use Blue Bossa as an example:



Step 1:

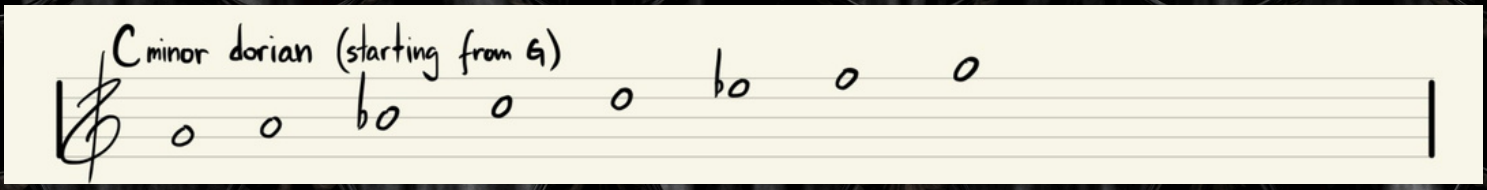
Apply traditional chord-scale theory to choose your preferred scales for each chord.

For the first chord, Cm7, I will opt for a C Dorian.



Step 2:

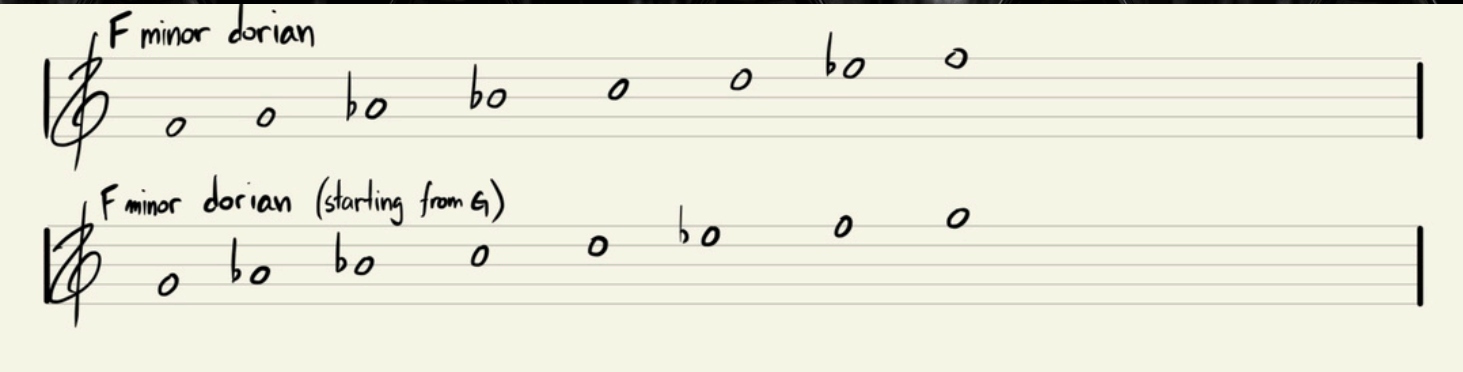
Choose any random pitch and rewrite the scale starting from that pitch. For example, here I will choose the note G.



Step 3:

Apply the same principle to all other chords, making sure you are writing the scale starting from a G, or the closest note to a G.

Here's the next chord, Fm7.

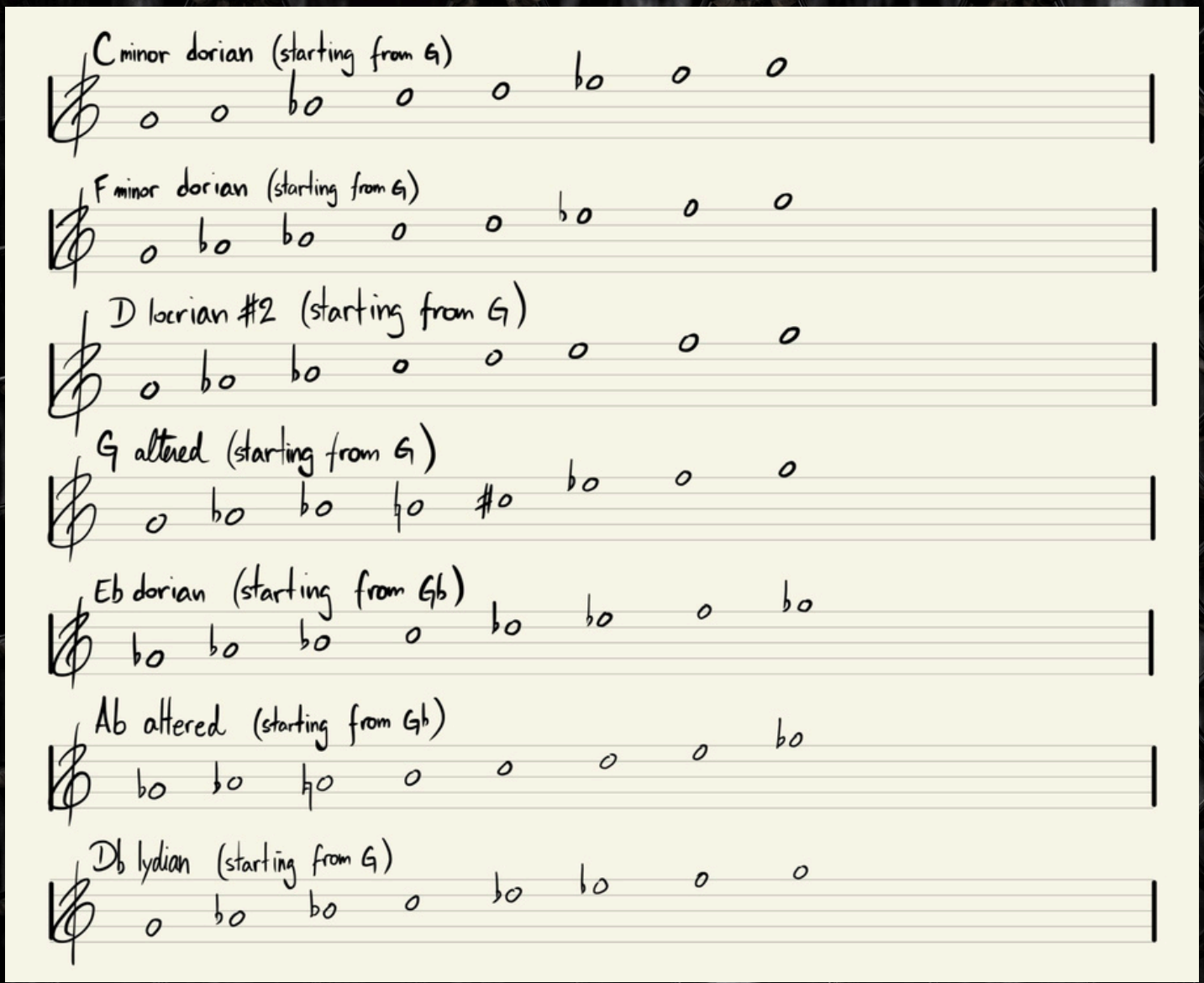


As mentioned earlier, there are multiple options of scales for each type of chord, according to your aesthetic preferences. If you don't know which scale to choose, just pick one randomly and use your ears to tell you if you like the sound.

Step 4:

Apply the same principle to all other chords, making sure you are writing the scale starting from a G, or the closest note to a G.

For dominant chords, I've opted for altered scales.



disclaimer:

A common question I get from students is

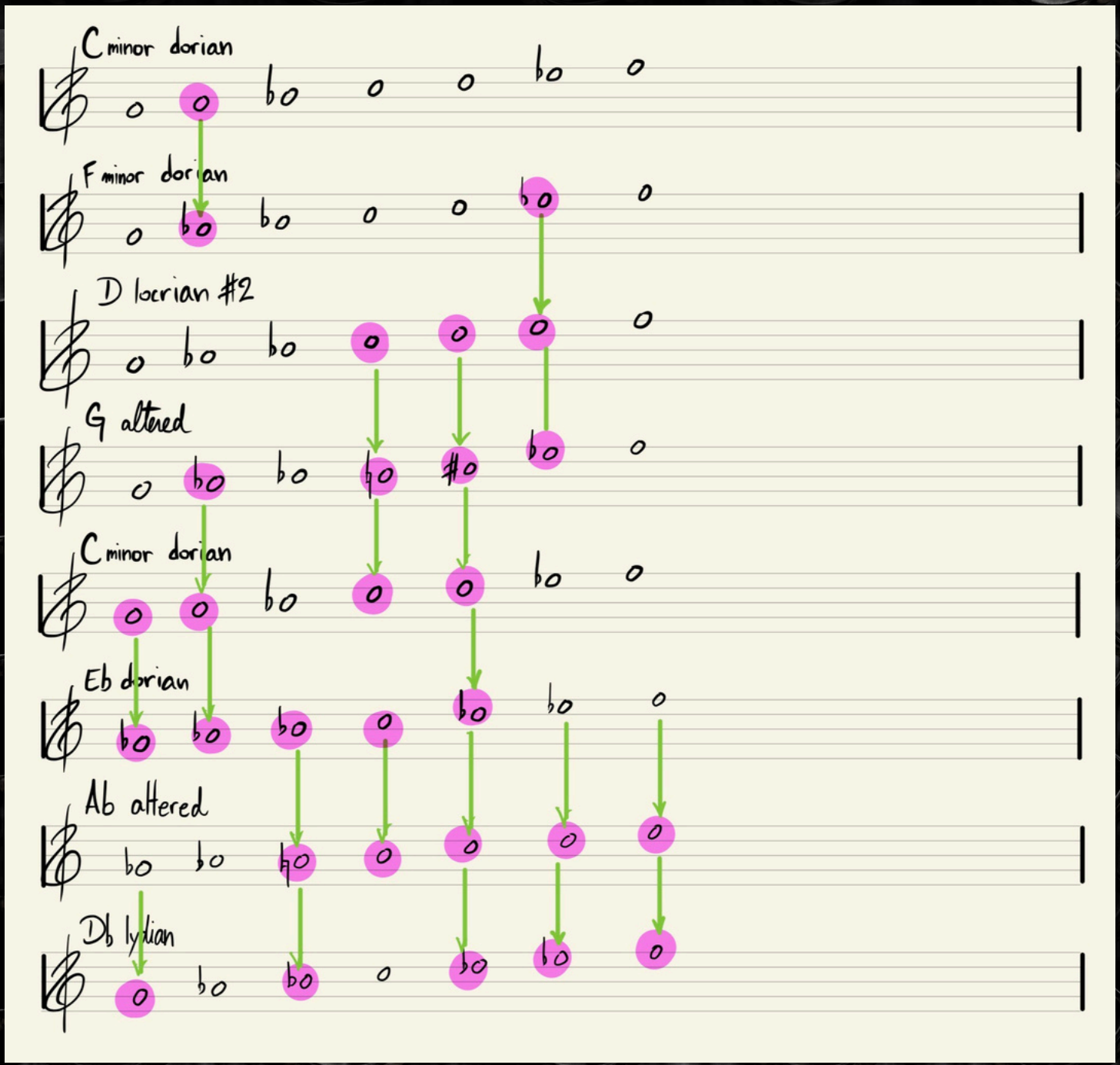
“who came up with these rules about what scales can/cannot be used with each type of chords?”

The answer is COMMON PRACTICE. Enough people starting using them until they became the standard practice.

in early jazz, for example, mixolydian was the most used scale over dominant chords; but during the bebop era the some musicians started using the altered scales, until it became the new common practice.

Step 5:

Once you have written all the scales in the sequence in which they appear in the piece, highlight just the changes between them. You will notice how many common tones they share.



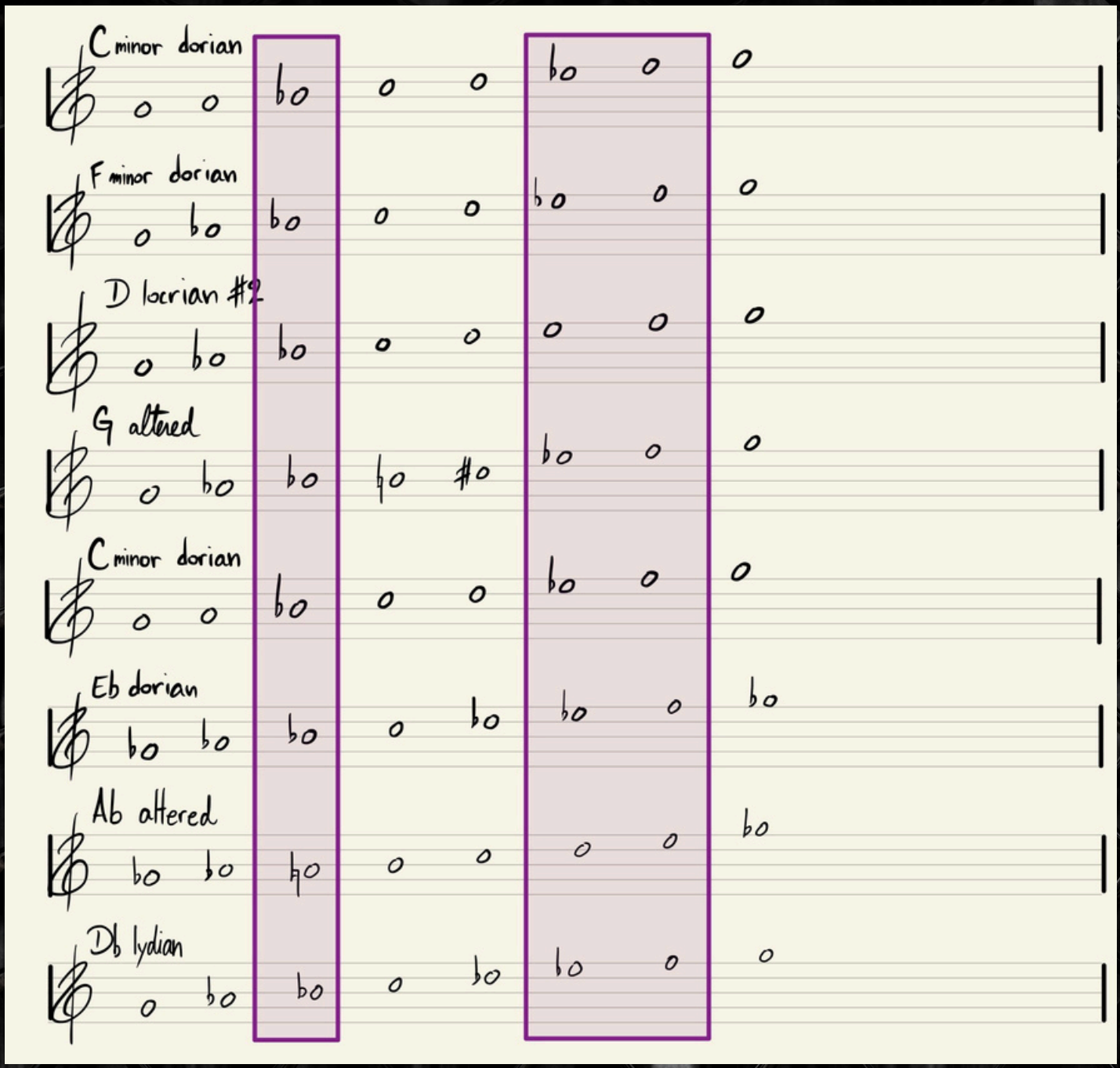
Step 6:

Now comes the fun part: instead of using all the notes from all the scales, focus on a subset of notes, such as a group of 3 notes.
Experiment improvising using only these notes. Create a short rhythmic motive (preferentially not starting on a downbeat) and apply it to all the scales.



Step 7:

Experiment with different subsets. The notes don't necessarily need to be adjacent.



Advantages:

By improvising with these subsets, one will naturally:

- **create good voice-leading**
- **utilize motivic development**
- **address the changes properly**
- **sound organic, seamlessly threading between chords.**
- subsets can be also treated as chords or ostinato for accompaniment/composition.
- instead of memorizing scales, you can memorize the changes (differences); the movement in the inner voices of the scales